Marie-Lou Laprise, PhD

Social scientist and lawyer studying collective intelligence and the social impact of AI

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RESEARCH PROGRAM

My research at the intersection of AI, law, and quantitative social science explores the social dynamics that emerge from unequal access to massive amounts of linked digital data and the large-scale deployment of agentic AI systems. My work combines computational simulations with the analysis of legal material and empirical data. I also work on the responsible use of AI for decision-making, research, and teaching.

Academic Appointments

Princeton University, Department of Sociology 2026-2027
Postgraduate Research Associate (postdoc)

Current Research Projects

Collective Computation in Multi-Agent Networks. I am developing a new modeling paradigm for studying **collective computation** in **networks of complex learning agents**. The modeling framework consists of a network of LLM-style agents, each observing an incomplete part of a structured ground truth, and learning to reconstruct it collectively. The project examines when communication improves **collective learning**, whether agents **specialize**, and how **unequal access to evidence** shapes individual and group performance. Learn more

Scale-Aware Law: Legal Design for Generative and Agentic AI. I study how legal frameworks should respond when generative and agentic AI increase the scale and speed of social conduct and automated action. Legal categories that ignore scale can make enforcement unbounded, while ignoring aggregate and emergent harms. The theory shows how **scale-sensitive classification** can instead enable **scale-robust enforcement** that addresses these harms. As a demonstration, I apply this framework to **financial regulation** (latency and information arbitrage) and **antitrust** (platform power). Learn more

LEGALMIX: Leveraging Legal Logic for Enhanced Reasoning Abilities in Language Models. Joint work with Brandon M. Stewart. We are developing an open framework for generating **difficult, verifiable legal reasoning tasks**, enabling the creation of both fixed **benchmarks** and dynamic **post-training data**. Learn more

Education

Princeton University
Ph.D. in Sociology and **Graduate Certificate in Statistics and Machine Learning** (2026); M.A. in Sociology (2023).
Dissertation: Essays on the outsourcing of evaluation, prediction, and enforcement after the digital turn.
Committee: Kim Lane Scheppele (chair), Adam Goldstein, and Brandon Stewart.
Final public oral examination: successfully completed July 10, 2026.

Université de Montréal. Maîtrise en droit, profil droit comparé / Master of Laws (LL.M.) (2021); thesis "Vers une théorie des fins de non-recevoir en droit privé québécois," **approved with "exceptional" mention and awarded the Quebec-wide annual LL.M. thesis prize**.

Université de Sherbrooke. Baccalauréat en droit / Bachelor of Laws (LL.B.) (2013); **Governor General's Academic Medal**, Canada's most prestigious student award.

Working Papers

M.-L. Laprise, "*Brokers Who Do Not Bridge: When Assessment, Not Access, Shapes Broker Advantage*"

ABSTRACT Structural theories describe economic brokerage as an opportune but fragile position bridging gaps between otherwise disconnected actors. In that view, brokering can undermine trust or eliminate the gaps that generate its value, and brokers need supporting institutions or deeper interpersonal ties to stabilize their role. Yet many corporate actors in positions of brokerage, from Visa to Amazon, have risen in market power, profit, and prominence even as networks transformed around them. When can brokering strengthen rather than undermine a broker's advantage?

I reconceptualize brokerage as outsourced relational work, in which the broker assumes no inventory risk and constructs viable matches between parties who cannot easily find *or evaluate* one another. Repeated matchmaking generates an informational byproduct that the broker can accumulate: knowledge of what makes pairings successful across the market, unavailable to clients who observe only their own dealings. An agent-based model of a matching market identifies conditions under which this informational advantage emerges and persists. Brokerage can provide assessment rather than access: clients outsource matching even when they can reach counterparties themselves, because the broker's predictions are valuable. Counterintuitively, the broker can become most central in regimes where it engages in the least bridging behavior: broker centrality is a product, not a primary source, of matchmaking quality.

While the model explores the dynamics of the broker's informational advantage, I theorize how this advantage can support a transition from intermediation to capture by the broker, as the broker becomes a principal selling the resource it once intermediated or monetizing data and analytics. Brief examples illustrate this transition. This is *transient brokerage*, a process that highlights how brokerage can disappear because of the broker's growing power rather than its fragility.

→ Agent-based model

→ Download manuscript (PDF)

M.-L. Laprise, "*Defining Predictive Estimands: Complex Patterns and Indeterminate Futures in Social Prediction*"

ABSTRACT AI has produced striking improvements in some prediction tasks but limited progress in forecasting human life trajectories; nonetheless, institutions use it to guide decisions. Explanations for this uneven performance commonly begin after a quantity is estimated, focusing on data quality, model capacity, or estimation error. Drawing on complexity science and information theory, this article develops a pre-modeling framework for defining prediction problems. Relations among observer, target, and estimand determine how target information storage and production contribute to two sources of prediction difficulty. Complexity arises when an estimand preserves intricate stored structure that the observer struggles to learn. Indeterminacy arises when an estimand depends on novel information produced beyond the observer's control. Machine learning can exploit complexity but cannot resolve indeterminacy. Four illustrations show how institutional and practical constraints shape prediction difficulty and the uses and limits of machine learning in social decision-making. A technical appendix provides a complete information-theoretic formalization.

→ Manuscript available on demand.

M.-L. Laprise (first and corresponding author), Frederick F. Wherry, and Edward P. Freeland, "*Financial Estrangement: Debt Collection, Precarity, and the Stratification of Institutional Trust*" (under review at *American Sociological Review*)

ABSTRACT Over a quarter of Americans report that their household has been contacted by a debt collector in the past year, and for many, this is their primary encounter with the institutions that enforce private claims. Building on the concepts of predatory inclusion and legal estrangement, we argue that civil debt enforcement constitutes a distinct, stratified pathway to institutional distrust—one that parallels and compounds the criminal justice pathway. We introduce the concept of financial estrangement to theorize how the terms of households' inclusion in credit markets shape their relations with the institutions that enforce private claims. Drawing on an original probabilistic survey of 2,115 U.S. adults, we show that debt-collection contact is pervasive, racially unequal, and not reducible to differences in household income or financial hardship. Americans overwhelmingly find widespread debt-collection practices unfair, particularly those who have experienced them. Careful analysis reveals that debt-collection contact is associated with perceiving courts as rarely or never fair, even after accounting for hardship levels, income, race/ethnicity, and arrest history. These findings suggest that civil legal processes tied to mass debt contribute to race- and class-stratified patterns of institutional trust.

→ Custom R code
→ Manuscript available on demand.

Publications

Charlie Eaton, Albina Gibadullina, Adam Goldstein, **M.-L. Laprise** (equal co-authors), "*How Private Equity Owns America: Corporate Raider, Main Street Invader, Monopoly Builder, Shadow Owner*" (forthcoming as a Roosevelt Institute white paper; under review at *Socio-Economic Review*)

ABSTRACT Private equity investment funds command increasing wealth and reach in the US economy, yet the scope and role of private equity (PE) remain ambiguous. This article assembles systematic data to provide a descriptive anatomy of PE's shifting strategies and ownership patterns in the U.S. since the 1980s. We theorize four interconnected roles: "corporate raider," "main street invader," "shadow owner," and "monopoly-builder." We then document the changing balance among them over time. We find a shift away from PE's traditional role as corporate raiders that specialize in restructuring publicly traded firms. PE investors increasingly focus on the agglomeration and rationalization of already private "main street" companies. PE-owned companies also increasingly stay private through longer hold times and sales to other PE funds. PE's expansion has helped spread the logic of shareholder value maximization to ever-more corners of the economy, but without the relative transparency and regulation of publicly traded companies.

M.-L. Laprise and Andreas Wiedemann (equal co-authors), "How Welfare and Credit Regimes Shape Economic Policies During Times of Crisis: The Case of Covid-19," (2025) *Socio-Economic Review* 23(3): 1439-1465

ABSTRACT How much economic support governments offered to households during the Covid-19 pandemic differed considerably across rich democracies. What explains this variation? We argue that institutional structures of welfare and credit regimes shape households' abilities to address income shortfalls and, as a result, governments' policy repertoire during crises. In countries with permissive credit regimes, economic support policies were more comprehensive when social policies were limited. Governments not only provided income support but also debt relief to shield households from default risks due to high pre-crisis debt leverage. Yet those countries ceased income support sooner as credit resumed its substitutive role vis-à-vis the welfare state. We provide evidence for our argument by examining pandemic policies from five OECD countries that vary in their social policies, credit access and household indebtedness. Our findings suggest that the privatization of risks imposes financial burdens on households that constrain governments' policy responses in times of crisis.

→ Reprinted as chapter 2 in 2026. *Viral Debt: The Production and Reproduction of Economic Vulnerability*, edited by Jodi Gardner, Mia Gray, and Frederick F. Wherry. New York: Routledge.

M.-L. Laprise, "Vers une théorie de la fin de non-recevoir en droit privé québécois" (2022) 67:3 *McGill Law Journal*, 329-367.

ABSTRACT The *fin de non-recevoir*, a type of bar to an action, results in the total and definitive paralysis of an otherwise available right of action. Despite its devastating effects and growing popularity, forty years after its recognition by the Supreme Court of Canada in *National Bank v. Soucisse*, its contours remain blurry and its substance, ambiguous. The legal community cannot agree on the definition or conditions of this poorly understood and under-theorized doctrine. This Article builds on a systematic review of recent cases to lay the groundwork for a theory of the *fin de non-recevoir* in Quebec private law. It introduces a crucial distinction, absent from contemporary commentary, between absolute and discretionary bars, it clarifies the role of discretionary bars in safeguarding the coherence of the law, and it systematizes how and when they may apply.

→ Cited multiple times by the Quebec Court of Appeal: see *Parent v. Bain*, 2026 QCCA 659; *Sols Verelli inc. v. Ville de Mercier*, 2026 QCCA 518; *Succession de Sheito*, 2026 QCCA 414; *9378-1417 Québec inc. v. Groupe Ilqueau inc.*, 2023 QCCA 351

Invited Talks and Conference Presentations

M.-L. Laprise (presenting first author) and Frederick F. Wherry (co-presenting), "*Financial Estrangement: How Debt Collection Depletes Public Trust in the Courts*," Colloquium of the Center for Work, Technology and Organization, Department of Management Science and Engineering, **Stanford University**, Stanford, CA. February 3, 2025.

M.-L. Laprise (presenting first author) and Frederick F. Wherry (co-presenting), "*Financialized Estrangement: Precarity, Debt Collection, and Public Trust in the Courts*," NYU Culture Workshop, Department of Sociology, **New York University**, New York, NY. January 30, 2025.

M.-L. Laprise, "*Making Language Models Smarter: Leveraging Legal Logic for Enhanced Reasoning Capabilities*," Graduate Certificate Colloquium of the Programs in Computational Science & Engineering and Statistics & Machine Learning, Princeton University, Princeton, NJ, April 24, 2024.

M.-L. Laprise (presenting) and Adam Goldstein, "*Divestment without Decarbonization: Private Equity and the Organizational Ecology of Dirty Work*," paper presentation, Society for the Advancement of Socio-economics annual meeting, Rio de Janeiro, Brazil. July 2023.

"*The Value of Methodological Reconsideration: Abolition, Complexity, Creativity and Crime*," invited discussant at the Fall Research Conference of the Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management, Washington, DC. November 17, 2022.

M.-L. Laprise, "*Making Markets for Data and Predictions: Information Flows, Corporate Power, and Rule of Law in the Digital Economy*," Law-Engaged Graduate Students seminar, Princeton University, Princeton, NJ. November 1, 2022.

M.-L. Laprise, "*Delinquent Debtors, Deceitful Creditors, or Doubtful Judges? Legal Non-cases, Fairness in Contract Enforcement, and Québec's Pleas in Bar*," paper presentation, Law & Society Association annual meeting, Lisbon, Portugal. July 13-16, 2022.

M.-L. Laprise, "*Comparative Law and the Making of Legal Doctrine: A Concept-Tracing Approach*," Law-Engaged Graduate Students seminar, Princeton University, Princeton, NJ. March 30, 2021.

Grants, Awards, Fellowships

Canadian Princeton Alumni Fund Named Fellowship 2023-2024

Law and Political Economy grant ($10,000; co-grantees: Brian Highsmith and Katherine Becker) 2022
Launched a local Law and Political Economy group and organized an inaugural speaker series sponsored by Princeton University Center for Human Values and the School of Public and International Affairs

Co-PI for the Debt Collection Lab at Princeton University (director: Frederick Wherry) 2021-2026

Graduate Student Merit Grant, Princeton University Center for Human Values 2020

Master of Laws

Annual Thesis Award, Association des Professeurs de Droit du Québec, awarded for the year's best LL.M. thesis across Quebec universities 2022

Honour List of the Rector, Université de Montréal 2021

Heenan Blaikie Excellence Scholarship ($10,000) and Fasken Scholarship for Civil Law ($5,000), awarded by the Université de Montréal, Faculty of Law 2019

J.A. DeSève Excellence Scholarship ($5,000), awarded by the Université de Montréal, Graduate and Postdoctoral Studies Vice-Rectorate 2019

Undergraduate Law Degree

Governor General's Academic Medal, awarded for the highest academic standing in the institution, across all undergraduate programs — 2014

Dean's List, Quebec Bar Association Prize, Bereskin & Parr Award, Heenan Blaikie Scholarship, Norton Rose Excellence Scholarship, Lord Reading Law Society Award, Fournier Demers Bureau Borduas Scholarship, Davies Ward Philips & Vineberg Award — 2011, 2012 & 2013

Teaching Experience

Princeton University, Department of Sociology

Lecturer for the Sociology Graduate Methods Camp — September 2026

Will provide advanced graduate-level instruction in quantitative and computational research methods, including the rigorous and ethical use of agentic AI in research and learning through structured Markdown project files, CLI-based AI tools, and coordinated multi-agent workflows

Princeton University, School of Public and International Affairs and Department of Sociology

Invited guest lecturer — March 20, 2024

"Law, Institutions, and Public Policy," taught by Professor Paul Starr

Assistant in Instruction (Preceptor) — 2021-2023

Courses: "Advanced Social Statistics" (Graduate level), Winter 2023; "The Western Way of War," Winter 2022; "Comparative Constitutional Law," Fall 2021; "Law, Institutions, and Public Policy," Winter 2021

- Taught portions of the main lectures, led weekly discussions about class material for groups of 6 to 15 students, held office hours, assisted students with their research papers and problem sets, and graded written work and exams.

Université de Montréal, Faculty of Law

Teaching Assistant: Contracts and Commercial Practices; Insurance Law — 2018-2019

Service

Peer reviewer for *Sociological Methods & Research*

Legal Practice

Guilbault Legal — Montréal, QC

Lawyer — 2018-2020

Part-time private practice in civil litigation, medical liability, and insurance law.

Spiegel Sohmer Inc. — Montréal, QC

Lawyer — 2014-2018

Full-time private practice in civil and commercial litigation, insurance law, and judicial review:

- Conducted research, developed strategies, and prepared proceedings, briefs, and opinions in files involving complex legal issues.
- Pleaded in English and in French in front of multiple courts and administrative tribunals, including trials on the merits and motions at the Court of Appeal.
- Participated in mediation sessions; negotiated and drafted settlement agreements.
- Advised clients and colleagues on risk assessment, risk management, and dispute prevention.

Co-head of the student recruiting committee 2016-2018

- Organized the annual hiring process, selected candidates, and conducted interviews.
- Supervised and mentored students; conducted appraisal meetings.

Other Collaborative Work

Member of the research and writing team for Baudouin, Jean-Louis, Deslauriers, Patrice and Moore, Benoît, *La responsabilité civile*, 9th ed., Montréal, Éditions Yvon Blais, 2021.

Member of the research and writing team for Moore, Benoît *et al.*, *Code civil du Québec: Annotations - Commentaires 2016-2017*, 1st ed., Montreal, Éditions Yvon Blais, 2016.

St-Hilaire, Maxime, with the collaboration of **M.-L. Laprise**, "The Codification of Human Rights in Canada," (2012) 42 R.D.U.S. 505.

St-Hilaire, Maxime, with the collaboration of David Gilles and **M.-L. Laprise**, *La codification des droits de la personne au Canada*, national report, International Academy of Comparative Law, 2nd Thematic Congress "Codification of the Law," National Taiwan University, Taipei, May 24-26, 2012.

Languages and Skills

Fluent in French and English

Computational methods: R, Python (PyTorch), and Julia; statistical and agent-based modeling; transformer pre-training and LLM inference

Research infrastructure: Distributed AI training on GPU clusters using TorchTitan/Flame; Weights & Biases, HPC, Modal, and Princeton HPC

Agentic research workflows: structured Markdown project files, CLI-based AI tools, and coordinated multi-agent workflows

Professional Associations

Member in good standing, Barreau du Québec (Quebec's professional licensing body for lawyers)

American Sociological Association (ASA)

Computational Social Science Society of the Americas

Society for Industrial and Applied Mathematics